



Or nearly nowhere. To the delight of many Indians worldwide, India won its first individual gold medal in Beijing. Congratulations to Abhinav Bindra—I know how hard he has worked in recent years and how much he deserved his medal. Many were also delighted at the bronze medals won by boxer Vijender Singh and wrestler Sushil Kumar.

But after the celebrations, we need to look at the realities. We are a nation of more than one billion people and yet this was our first individual gold medal. You only have to look at our world-class performances over many years in team sports like hockey and cricket to know that we certainly don't lack sporting talent. Unfortunately, cricket isn't an Olympic sport and doesn't look like becoming one. But I simply don't believe that the athletic skills required to succeed at the highest level in cricket can't also be deployed across a wider range of sports, particularly individual disciplines.

That's why in 2005, I set up the Mittal Champions Trust (MCT) targeted at improving our medals haul at the London Olympics in 2012. To an extent, we were able to help Bindra on his way to gold at Beijing. But there is an enormous amount of work to be done if we are to come better than 50th in the London medals table.

First of all we need commitment from schools, colleges and places of work to do all they can to promote sporting activities for students and employees. And not just cricket. Cricket will always be at the heart of India's sporting achievements. I too am a cricket fan. But we don't have to be a one-trick pony. There were 302 individual and team gold medals on offer at Beijing, so there's plenty of choice. Then we need facilities and world-class coaches. And this means investment. Here governments at the state and national-level can help, as well as sponsoring

Top honours:
Abhinav Bindra brought home India's first individual gold medal

companies and institutions such as the MCT. Last but not most importantly, we need Indian men and women to be inspired by the dream of Olympic gold.

India is experiencing a great momentum in its economic transformation. As that journey continues, we need to draw the nation together. We need to build pride in everything we do. High-profile sporting success is one way to help foster such pride. Sport also confers great benefits on individuals and communities who take part in it, even at the most basic levels. The

most obvious benefit is improved health and fitness. As India becomes more prosperous, our people will become more prone to the diseases of affluence—obesity, diabetes and heart disease. We can promote health through sports as a means of avoiding these problems. The benefits of sports can be summed up as greater self-confidence, more will-power, greater discipline, and the willingness to take on and succeed in challenges that might have earlier seemed too difficult or simply impossible. I know from personal experience how sport can play its role in a balanced life, however busy it gets. I still try to fit in an hour of exercise every day and I am convinced this hour makes the other 23 hours of the day more productive.

We need a supreme national and individual effort to improve our results across all sports. We need to start now. It won't be easy, but we have the talent and determination to do it. With

the right levels of investment and commitment, India can do a China. And the effects could be far more wide-reaching for the country than people might initially imagine. I even warned my own top executives recently that they should strive to remain fit because it will enable them to function better.

The author is chairman and CEO of steel major Arcelor Mittal.

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